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THE SHE LIST

Vrinda Grover, *53*
Advocate, Supreme Court

ACCOMPLISHMENT
As one of the leading human rights lawyers in India, Grover has stood firmly with those who have been wronged by the state or society

FIGHTING FOR CITIZENS' RIGHTS

FOR VRINDA GROVER, human rights are universal. Defending the four accused in the Nirbhaya rape case against a death sentence, was, thus, more than just a job for her. "I had no difficulty in representing the convicts because I believe no matter how heinous the offence, the death penalty is neither a deterrent nor does it change the lives and circumstances of the victims of the offence. It simply gives greater arbitrary power to the state," she says. Yet, on the other hand, Grover has consistently stood alongside rape and assault victims. In the Bilkis Bano case, when the accused were given remission, she intervened against the decision.

In her 30 years of practising human rights law in India, she says the strength to continue to fight for justice comes from the perseverance she sees in her clients. "If a person who has suffered injustice is willing to persevere, the least I can do is continue to represent them," she says. Grover recently concluded a long and challenging trial of 10 years at a trial court in Muzaffarnagar, where she represented a gang rape victim. "I have learnt through my experience, when you are representing in court persons who come from marginalised sections, the system attempts to exhaust you.... If you wish to secure justice, you shouldn't allow the system to tire you out."

Another crucial case for her was the writ petition she filed on behalf of the *Kashmir Times* editor, Anuradha Bhasin, against the internet suspension in Kashmir in 2019. "Kashmir was reduced to an information blackhole. After our case, not only did the court reject the state's reasoning of national security concerns allowing them to deny people fundamental rights, but it also held that the right to internet to access other rights is a fundamental right," she says.

Grover believes that change begins from the grassroots. But the pursuit of justice can be daunting when one goes up against powerful institutions. "I'm currently waiting for a chargesheet for a writ petition filed in the Delhi HC against police officers who beat a boy to death during the 2020 Delhi riots. It's been three years. Fear and exhaustion is natural, I don't think anyone should pretend they are above it," she says. When all else fails, Grover draws courage from what she as a human rights lawyer stands for. "The law must be equal. That is the promise of our Constitution and one we all have a responsibility to uphold." ■

-Sonali Acharjee

KEEPING IT BALANCED

"You must be passionate about work, but not consumed by it. I do a lot of fun things, I take my holidays. I don't wish to be one-dimensional"

EARLY YEARS
Grover grew up in Delhi in the '80s, witnessing events like the anti-Sikh riots, and reading about a host of social justice and women's rights struggles. That period, she says, helped her understand how to think of social justice